FREE GUIDE

Health Check Visits

Social stories, a sensory needs card and questions to ask, so visits to the GP and the sexual health clinic are predictable and you know your rights.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic young people and adults, with the parents, carers, teachers, SNAs and support workers who help them.

NCCA STAGE
Junior Cycle (GP visits) · Senior Cycle and LCA · Adults

Easy read

A health check helps me stay well. I know what will happen. I can ask questions. I can say stop.

How to use this resource

- Read the social story a few days before the visit, and again on the day. Change any detail that is different for you.
- Fill in the sensory needs card at home. Take it to the appointment and hand it to the staff.
- Choose the stories that suit you. The sexual health clinic story is for adults, or for young people with a parent or trusted adult when advised by their GP.
- Phone ahead if you can. Ask about quiet times, waiting rooms and who you will see.

© 2026 Autism & Me (autismandme.ie). Free to print and share for non-commercial educational use.

Version 1.0 · health-check-visits

Social story 1: Going to the GP

A GP is a family doctor. This story is about a normal visit. Your visit may be a little different. That is OK.

1



I have an appointment

I know the day and time. I write it on my calendar. A trusted person may come with me.

© autismandme.ie

2



I travel there

I leave in good time. I have my medical card or money if I need it.

© autismandme.ie

3



I check in

I tell the person at the desk my name. I say 'I have an appointment at ___'.

© autismandme.ie

4



I wait

I may wait for some minutes. I can bring headphones, a book or a game. I can ask for a quiet space.

© autismandme.ie

5



The doctor calls my name

I go into a room. The doctor says hello. I can sit down.

© autismandme.ie

6



I say why I came

I tell the doctor what is wrong. I can read from my note.

© autismandme.ie

7



The doctor checks me

The doctor may look, listen or touch. They tell me first. I can say 'Please tell me before you touch me.'

© autismandme.ie

8



I ask questions

I ask what I do not understand. I can ask the doctor to write it down.

© autismandme.ie

9



I go home

I take any prescription. I do what I planned. I did a good job.

© autismandme.ie



The doctor is there to help me.



I can say stop at any time.

© Autism & Me · autismandme.ie



What I tell the doctor is private.

Notes for adults

- Ring the surgery before the visit. Ask for a quiet room, the first or last appointment, or a longer appointment. Many surgeries can do this if they know.
- Practise the visit at home with a toy stethoscope, torch or play kit. Visit the surgery first, if you can, to see the room.
- Young people under 18 usually go with a parent or carer. Include the young person in the conversation, and let them speak for themselves as much as they can.
- Medical staff should not need a diagnosis to make adjustments. Ask, and they should listen.

autismandme.ie

© Autism & Me · autismandme.ie

Social story 2: Going to a sexual health clinic

This story is for adults, and for older teenagers going with a parent, carer or a trusted adult. A sexual health clinic is a place for sexual health checks, advice and contraception. Many people go. It is a normal health service. Find your local clinic on sexualwellbeing.ie. Many clinics are free.

1



I find out

I look at sexualwellbeing.ie or ring the clinic. I ask if I need to book. I ask what will happen.

© autismandme.ie

2



I make an appointment

I choose a day and time that suits me. I tell someone I trust if I want to.

© autismandme.ie

3



I arrive

I tell the receptionist my name or the number I was given. The clinic is private.

© autismandme.ie

4



I wait

The waiting room may have other people. They are there for the same reason. I can use my headphones.

© autismandme.ie

5



A nurse or doctor sees me

They ask me questions about my health. I tell the truth. They do not judge me.

© autismandme.ie

6



The test

A test may be a urine sample, a blood test or a swab. They tell me first and show me what they will do. I can ask them to go slowly.

© autismandme.ie

7



I can ask anything

I can ask about contraception and condoms, and what the test is for.

© autismandme.ie

8



I get my results

They tell me how I will get my results, by phone, text or in person. I ask when to expect them.

© autismandme.ie

9



I go home

I look after myself. I did something good for my health.

© autismandme.ie



Looking after my sexual health is responsible.



The clinic keeps my information private.

I can say stop. I can say no to a test.

Notes for adults

- Check sexualwellbeing.ie for what each clinic offers, the cost and eligibility for the free contraception scheme.
- Respect privacy. For adults, do not go into the appointment unless asked. Offer to wait outside or to come in if the person wants support.
- For under-18s, follow your school's policy and speak to the GP about confidentiality and consent. Do not make promises of secrecy that you cannot keep. If a young person tells you something that worries you, follow Children First and your DLP.
- Ask clinic staff if they can show a photo of the room, explain each step, or offer a calm space.

autismandme.ie

My sensory needs card

Fill this in, print it, and show it to staff at the start of the appointment. You can hand it over without speaking. You can write what is right for you.

I find these things hard

Noise, lights, smells or crowds. Hard for me: _____

Being touched. Hard for me: _____

Waiting. Hard for me: _____

Something else that is hard for me: _____

These things help

Please tell me before you touch me: _____

Please explain each step: _____

Please give me time to answer. I may need to think: _____

Please write things down for me: _____

I would like to bring (headphones, sunglasses, a person):

_____

Something else that helps: _____

About me

My name: _____

I may stop talking if I am stressed. If this happens, I will:

_____

My support person (name and number): _____

Tip

You do not need a diagnosis to ask for adjustments. You can say 'I find it easier if you tell me what will happen first.'

© Autism & Me · autismandme.ie

Questions to ask

You can ask questions at any health visit. Write them down before you go. It is OK to read from your list.



What is wrong?

'What do you think is causing this?'

© autismandme.ie



What will happen?

'What will happen in this test? How long will it take?'

© autismandme.ie



What do I do next?

'What should I do after today? Can you write it down?'

© autismandme.ie



When will I know?

'When will I get my result? How will you tell me?'

© autismandme.ie



What if it gets worse?

'Who do I ring if I feel worse?'

© autismandme.ie



I do not understand

'Please say that again in simpler words.'

© autismandme.ie

Your rights at a health visit



I can bring someone with me.



I can ask staff to explain things in plain words.



I can say stop. I can say no.



I can take time to think before I decide.



My health information is private.

© Autism & Me · autismandme.ie

I can ask for things to be written down.

If something does not feel right

If anyone touches you in a way that makes you feel unsafe, or does something you did not agree to, say stop, leave if you can, and tell someone you trust. You can ring the Gardaí, or the Dublin Rape Crisis Centre on 1800 77 88 88 (free, 24 hours). In an emergency ring 112 or 999.

Screening and checks

The HSE runs screening programmes for different health checks. HSE screening programmes such as CervicalCheck send invitations; check hse.ie. If you get an invitation and you are not sure what to do, ask your GP to explain. You can ask for a longer appointment and a chance to see the room first.

Notes for adults

- Screening invitations by post can be confusing or frightening. Help the person to read them, and ask the GP practice about adjustments.
- Preparing for intimate checks takes time. Use pictures and rehearse the steps. The person must always be able to say stop, and staff must respect that.
- Do not make decisions for an adult. Support them to understand, choose and speak up.

autismandme.ie

Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 2 *Making Healthy Choices* and Strand 3 *Relationships and Sexuality*: looking after health and knowing where to get help.
- Senior Cycle SPHE: new specification published 2024, being introduced for fifth years, including sexual health and accessing services. Leaving Certificate Applied: Social Education.
- Primary SPHE (1999), strand **Myself**, strand unit *Taking care of my body*: visits to the doctor and keeping well.
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs: use social stories, rehearsal and visual supports to prepare for new experiences.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Your GP or public health nurse

For questions about puberty, periods, body changes or health checks.

HSE Sexual Wellbeing

Free information, free STI testing and free contraception information at sexualwellbeing.ie.

Emergency

112 or 999 — Gardaí, ambulance or fire. Use it if someone is in danger now.

Rape Crisis Help

Dublin Rape Crisis Centre national helpline, free and 24 hours: 1800 77 88 88.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

autismandme.ie

© 2026 Autism & Me, Waterford, Ireland. Text, illustrations and design © autismandme.ie. You may print and share this resource free of charge for non-commercial educational use, with this notice kept in place. It may not be sold, changed or republished without written permission. This resource gives general information and does not replace medical, legal or safeguarding advice. Phone numbers and services were checked in October 2026; please confirm them locally before you share. Feedback: contactautismandme@gmail.com